2nd Oracle of War, Victory and Restoration

(12:1—14:21)

The second oracle continues many of the themes of the previous oracle.

- *It also begins with the title* מַשָּׂא *(= burden).*
- *Whereas the former oracle began in poetry and ended in prose, this one is largely prose and contains only a short poetic section.*
- *The city of Jerusalem is the central focus.*

War and Victory

(12:1-9)

This war scene is international (12:1). In two striking metaphors, Yahweh describes Jerusalem under siege.

- *Jerusalem is an intoxicating cup of wine (12:2).*
- *Jerusalem is an immovable rock lacerating anyone who tries to dislodge it (12:3).*

Under Yahweh's watchful eye, Judah's leaders will be like a consuming fire to her enemies. Yahweh will fight on the side of his people, and the weakest among them will be as strong as David, while the house of David will be like the heavenly Man of War, the Mal'ak Yahweh (12:4-9).

The Pierced One

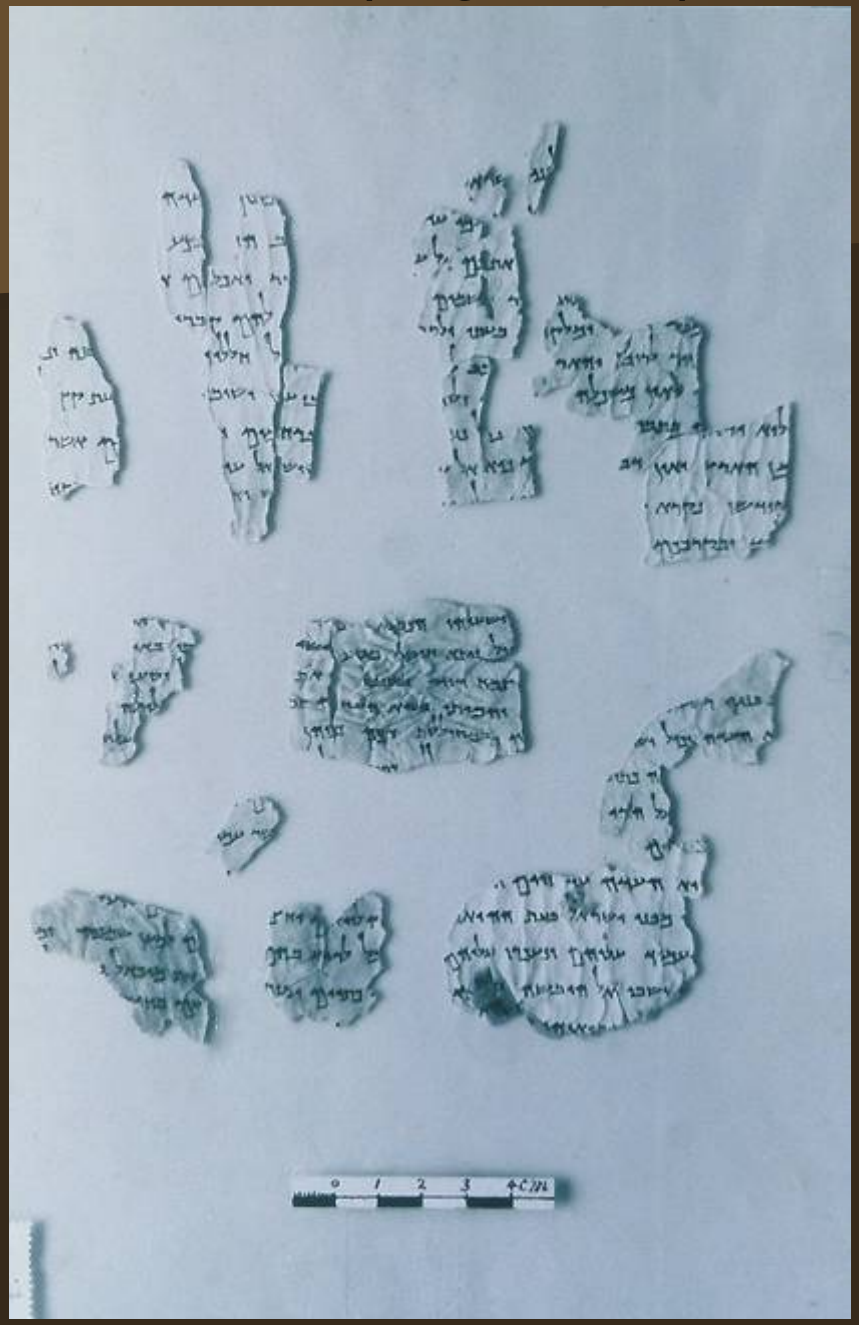
(12:10)

The aftermath of the war will be followed by compassion and mourning for one who is pierced (12:10). Textual variations leave the identity of the pierced one unclear.

- *The MT and 4QXII^{c} read, "They will look on me…" (followed in NIV, NASB, NEB, ESV, ASV, KJV).*
- *Other Hebrew manuscripts read, "They will look on him…" (followed in RSV, NAB, NRSV, CEV, JB).*
- *The LXX reads, "They will turn towards me because they have insulted me…"*

Whatever the textual resolution, John certainly understood the passage to refer to Christ (Jn. 19:37).

4Q285 (fragment 5)



Labeled the “pierced Messiah” text, this fragment made international headlines in 1991 when it was read by two scholars as referring to a “pierced messiah” (R. Eisenman and M. Wise).

The unpointed text is capable of two renderings, either: a) the enemy will put the Messiah to death, or b) the Messiah will have the enemy leader put to death.

While the first option would form a striking parallel with the death of Jesus, most scholars opt for the second on the basis that the larger context in the DSS views the Community Leader as the victorious son of David.

Mourning for the Pierced One
(12:11—13:1)

The people's mourning would be so intense that it would be comparable to grief for the death of a firstborn son or the pagan ritual mourning for the fertility deities.

- *Each Israelite clan would mourn separately (12:11-14).*
- *A cleansing fountain for purification from sin would be opened to the family of David and all Jerusalem (13:1).*

Suppression of Idols and False Prophets

(13:2-6)

In this purification, all traces of idolatry would be removed and false prophecy would be condemned.

- *Parents would not hesitate to obey the Deuteronomic injunction for execution—even if the false prophet were their own child (cf. Dt. 13:1-11; 18:20).*
- *The traditional prophetic garb—the garment of hair (cf. 2 Kg. 1:8)—would be discarded.*
- *The very title "prophet" would be disclaimed, and any marks that might be suspected of being self-inflicted wounds induced in a prophetic ecstasy would be passed off as wounds from a friendly scuffle. (Though some have thought that 13:6 might be interpreted messianically, the context is against it.)*

Song of the Sword
(13:7-9)

This poetic interjection resumes the theme of the shepherd from the 1st oracle.

- *The Good Shepherd is one who stands as Yahweh's associate.*
- *The sword of execution is called forth, and the Good Shepherd is struck down, scattering the flock.*
- *Most of the flock will perish, though a third would survive by passing through the fires of purification and refinement.*
- *In the end, this remnant would become the covenant people of God. (The words "you are my people" and "I am your God" is the basic covenant formulary.)*

The Eschatological Language of the Prophets

יוֹם יְהוָה (= Day of Yahweh)

בְּאַחֲרִית הַיָּמִים (= in days to come, in the last days)

בְּיוֹם הַהוּא (= in that day)

All these expressions are fluid and have a semantic range that includes the near future as well as the indeterminate future.

Day of Yahweh

NEAR FUTURE

- *Judgment by exile on the unfaithful nations of Israel and Judah*
- *Judgments in history on the nations surrounding Israel and Judah*

FAR FUTURE

- *Judgment on a blasphemous world by universal cataclysm*
- *Disintegration of the universe*
- *Salvation of God's people*
- *Victory of God's armies*
- *Universal peace*

War and Victory

(14:1-15)

The battle for Jerusalem is described as the "Day of Yahweh" in which all the nations will put the city to siege while committing all the atrocities of war (14:1-2).

- *Yahweh will himself intervene to save the city, appearing on the Mt. of Olives with the angelic armies (14:3, 5b).*
- *In the midst of a great earthquake, life-giving water will flow from the Mediterranean to the Dead Sea (14:4-5a, 8).*
- *Jerusalem will be secure forever, her enemies will be destroyed, the terrain and seasons will be affected, and Yahweh will reign as King over the whole world (14:6-15).*

Judgment and Salvation of the Nations
(14:16-21)

Survivors from the nations will be compelled to come to Jerusalem to worship Yahweh Tsabaoth, celebrating Succoth (14:16-19).

- *Every item in the city will be consecrated as holy.*
- *No longer will there be any distinction between the holy and profane, for everything will be holy from the horses' bells to the cooking pots.*
- *Racketeers (Canaanites) will be banned from the temple.*

Interpreting the Song of the Sword

HISTORICAL

If the Song of the Sword is interpreted in the context of the OT, then the attack upon the shepherd is the downfall of the dynasty of David. The scattering of the flock is the exile.

FUTURISTIC

If it is interpreted in the context of the NT, then the shepherd is Christ and the scattering is the flight of his disciples.

Two NT Passages clearly quote from the 2nd oracle

The pierced one (12:10b)

- *John's Gospel links the pierced one to the soldier's action of piercing Jesus' side with the spear at his crucifixion (Jn. 19:33-37).*
- *In the Revelation, however, it is not only Israel who views the pierced messiah and mourns, but all the peoples of the earth (Rv. 1:7).*

The shepherd who is struck down (13:7b)

- *Jesus himself quoted the Song of the Sword with reference to himself (Mt. 26:31//Mk. 14:27; cf. Jn. 10:11-12; 16:32a).*
- *The striking down of the flock might refer to the Jewish wars in the first and/or second Jewish revolts (60s AD and 130s AD), or if taken in a Christian sense, it might refer to persecutions in the apostolic era.*

Eschatological Implications

The visions in the 2nd oracle are very much at home in the environment of Jewish apocalyptic.

- *Dispensationalists tend to see this oracle as pointing toward the end of the age, the period of great tribulation, the second coming of Christ, and the millennial kingdom to follow.*
- *Amillennialists tend to see this oracle as pointing toward a spiritual fulfillment in the church.*
- *Still others see a possible double entendre that has both a literal fulfillment (historically) and also a spiritual one (symbolizing the eschatological future).*

Eschatological Implications cont.--

The wars described are in the spirit of the “battle of the great day of God Almighty” (Rv. 16:14, 16; 19:19).

The fountain of blessing in Jerusalem and the rise of the family of David to prominence seems messianic in some sense.

The establishment of God’s kingdom over the whole world resonates with the kingdoms of the world serving Christ (Rv. 11:15; 19:16) and the descent of the New Jerusalem (Rv. 21-22).

At the same time, there is no distinction in Zechariah between what the NT describes as the “first” coming of Christ and the “second” coming of Christ. If the vision concerns the Messiah, the images of both advents are superimposed over each other in Zechariah.

If the final two apocalyptic oracles are credited to Zechariah in the 6th century BC, then they function much like his previous visions...

...they assure the remnant community that their task in building the second temple is part of a much larger future in God's long-range purposes.